

To all National Spiritual Assemblies in Europe

1994-03-24 • UHG • Nationale Geistige Räte

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1994-03-24

To all National Spiritual Assemblies in Europe

Hearts grieved by the death of the late Mrs. Mary Ann Baha'u'llah
doro Thy friends who served the Service of the Cause of God extended
over more than half a century. She contributed significantly to the
Training of the members of the National Assembly of the British Isles and the first
Ary of the European, played a vital part in the history of Africa and the
by Shoghi Effendi, served the world center during the last days of his
life, and as a member of the Continental Board of Counsellors of Europe.
These services, as well as her indefatigable labor and sterling qualities
ties, her tenacity, perseverance and unflinching loyalty have enriched
the annals of the British Isles and set forth a worthy example.

Arduously pursuing the holy Shrine of progress her noble soul abhors
dom. Advise the memorial gathering of the community of the United Kingdom. 177 .5

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1993-1996 • The Three Year Plan

□75 requesting the National Spiritual Assembly of Germany hold a memorial service
at the Temple of Europe. Also advising the European National Assemblies
to hold commemorative gatherings of their communities.

Convey our loving sympathy to her beloved daughter, to her members
and family.

Universal House of Justice

179

Murder of Three Iranian Pioneers in South Africa

28 March 1994

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

dear Bahá'í friends,

with you certain details relevant to the murder of three Iranian Bahá'í pioneers to South Africa for the information of the friends throughout the world.

As you may have learned from the wide publicity which the incident received, on 13 March Mr. Houshmand Anvari, Dr. Shamam Bakhshandegi and Mr. Riaz Razavi were shot to death by gunmen who burst into the Bahá'í center at Mdantsane, Ciskei, where some adults and children had gathered for meetings. Mr. Anvari, who served as caretaker of the Bahá'í center, had been painting a portion of the building when four young gun-men ordered him to go inside at a time when children's classes were ending and the friends were preparing for a meeting concerning the international year of the family. Mr. Razavi, Auxiliary Board member for Ciskei, and Dr. Bakhshandegi had been invited especially to consult with the friends at this meeting. The gunmen ordered the "whites," these three Iranian friends, to stand apart from the others, lined them up against the wall with their hands above their heads, searched them, and then fired at them with automatic weapons as their fellow believers looked on in utter shock. The gunmen fled immediately, using Mr. Razavi's car to get away. Mr. Razavi and Mr. Anvari were killed instantly; Dr. Bakhshandegi died upon arrival at a hospital in Mdantsane.

The three deceased friends lived in South Africa near the border with Ciskei and focused their Bahá'í services on that homeland. Mr. Razavi, 44, director of finance at the University of Fort Hare in Ciskei, pioneered in 1978.

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Message from the Universal House of Justice

□ 1976 to Lesotho where two years later he married Vera Paquay, a Belgian pioneer, and in 1979 was elected to the National Spiritual Assembly. In 1983 the Razavi family moved to King William's Town in South Africa from which in subsequent years Mr. Razavi focused his attention on Ciskei as a

bahá'í teacher and then as an Auxiliary board member since August 1989.

he is survived by his wife, vera, their 15-year-old son, jalal, and 12-year-old daughter, roushie.

mr. Anvari, 43, a computer programmer, first went to the United States from his native Iran to complete his studies, and in 1990 journeyed with his family to South Africa for the second time, settling in East London in order to serve both in South Africa and Ciskei. He and his wife Dina established a crèche at the bahá'í center in Mdantsane and also founded a weekend tutorial school in King William's Town. Mr. Anvari was a member of the local Spiritual Assembly of East London and engaged in public relations work for the faith. He also served as caretaker/manager of the Mdantsane bahá'í center where he was killed. He has left behind his wife and their three young children: Vaffa, 8; Nava, 5; and Ava, 2.

Dr. Bakhshandegi, 28, a dentist, served on the staff of the Cecilia Makwani Hospital in Mdantsane, Ciskei, as supervisor of the community dental section. He was born in Mauritania where his parents were pioneers, and spent his years as a child and youth there, becoming a brilliant student, and eventually attaining proficiency in five languages. In the early 1980s he went as a pioneer to South Africa with his parents, Dr. Amin Bakhshandegi, also a dentist, and Mrs. Badri Bakhshandegi. While a university student in Johannesburg for several years, he was a member of the local Spiritual Assembly. At the end of his studies, he returned to East London, where he served as secretary of the local Spiritual Assembly and as public relations officer for his region. Just before his death Dr. Bakhshandegi had completed the first scientific dental research done in Ciskei for which he will be awarded a master's degree posthumously. He had already won, along with two others, the Elida Ponds Research Award in dentistry for his work. Dr. Bakhshandegi is survived by his parents and his sister, Djam.

The killers have not yet been identified nor have their motives been clarified, but the view has been expressed in press reports that their action was racially motivated. The incident evoked condemnatory statements from of-

ficials of the South African government, the African National congress, and various religious communities. The South African National Spiritual Assembly reported unprecedented publicity of the faith in their country as 179.4

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1993–1996 • The Three Year Plan

□77a result. many of the published reports mention that the bahá'ís of South Africa have a 40-year history of multiracialism. Stories distributed by the wire services, the Associated press and reuters, have appeared in newspapers around the world. other international media have also carried reports. on 19 march, a dignified funeral service, attended by some five hundred people, was conducted at the town hall of a suburb of east london called cambridge. in addition to the bahá'ís who came from all over southern Africa as well as from many local communities in South Africa, the attendees included the mayor of east london, the chancellor and a member of the council of the university of fort hare, two members of the National party for that region and many other sympathizers from the public. in his eulogy the mayor of east london regarded these deaths as a sacrifice for peace and the unity of mankind. After several hours of prayers, readings from the Sacred Scriptures, eulogies and expressions of sympathy, the three bodies of these dearly loved and respected friends were taken to the cemetery and finally laid to rest side by side. upon receiving news of this tragic incident from the National Spiritual Assembly of South Africa, the house of justice responded with the following message on 14 march:

Shocked grieved News violent death household and an Ari, ShAmAmbAkh ShANdegi and riAz rAz Avi in ciSkei. profoundly impressed STerliNg exAmple Set by Their dedicATion cA use bAhá'u'lláh in whoSe Service They were directly engaged when STruck down by ASSASSiNS' bullets. deeply Symp AThize irrep ArAble loss Their deAr f AmilieS and frieNdS. mA y All heAr TS be comforted by promise bleSSed beA uTy ThAT They ThAT hA ve forSAkeN Their couNtry

in p AT h god ANd SubSequeNTly ASceNded uNT o hiS preSeNce ShAll
be bleSSed by coNcourSe oN high ANd Their NAmES recorded by
peN glory AmoNg Such AS hA ve l Aid dowN Their liveS AS mAr TyrS
pAT h god. coNfideNT joyouS welcome Abhá kiNgdom TheSe diS-
TiNguiShed SoulS. ArdeNTly prA yiNg holy ShriNeS Their progreSS
diviNe worldS. AlSo offeriNg SupplicATioNS behAlf All rel ATiveS
frieNdS. Advise hold memoriAl gATheriNgS Throug houT SouTh
Africa.

with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat179.7

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Appointment of New Continental Counselor

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]